

allow you to benefit from those assets; often, the trustee is instructed to provide you with an income from the assets.

AMERICANS' UNIQUE TAX PROBLEM

Which brings us back to the problem faced by Americans. The U.S. border police are essentially charged with a double mission: to keep poor people from getting into the United States and to keep rich people from getting out. Illegal immigration is a problem on one side; illegal emigration is a problem on the other.

Millions of people sneak into the United States. Millions sneak out. Those who come in do so to make their fortunes. Those who sneak out often do so to protect the fortunes that they created already. Even today, the United States is still a good place to make a fortune—though probably not as good as it was and probably not as good as the emerging economies. But when it comes to protecting and preserving a fortune, the United States is not a good place to be.

The world is a competitive place. Poor people compete with each other for jobs. Rich people compete, too. Wealth, beyond what is needed for survival, is relative. You have a certain amount. Someone else has more. Standards for being “wealthy” change with place and time. A person with very little money may still be considered wealthy in an African village. Put him in Zurich and the locals will put him on welfare.

In 1950, a “millionaire” was a very wealthy person in America. Now there’s a millionaire next door and two down the street. If you own a house in a good neighborhood, you’re likely to be a millionaire. The standards for what people consider wealthy have moved on. It takes a lot more money to be considered rich than it did a half-century ago.

If you want to be rich by U.S. standards, you can safely stay put in the United States. You’ll be taxed like the rest of us. You’ll get the asset growth, more or less, that everyone else gets.